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20 AI Agents That Pay for Themselves

Build the agents and recurring routines that save a business money from the first week, in Claude or ChatGPT

DENISE CULLOM

Before you start

For more than 25 years I ran operations for coaching, consulting, SaaS and digital businesses. As COO of a business coaching company, I helped grow revenue from about \$5 million to \$16 million while keeping 35% net profit margins, with a team of more than 50 people.

Margins like that don't come from working harder. They come from refusing to pay people to do the same low-value task twice. Every week, my job was to find the work that repeated, write down how it should be done, and get it off the plates of the people we were paying to think.

AI agents are the cheapest way to do that I've ever seen. A \$20-a-month subscription can now draft the email replies, write the weekly report, chase the unpaid invoices, and summarize the meeting, on a schedule, while you do something else. Most businesses never get there. They open a chat window, ask a question, get a decent answer, and go back to doing the work by hand.

This book closes that gap. It starts with the absolute basics of Claude and ChatGPT, then walks you through 20 specific agents, department by department, with the exact instructions to paste, the files to give them, the schedule to put them on, and the math on what each one saves.

Who this book is for

- **Business owners and managers** who know AI could save them time but haven't turned it into something that runs every week.
- **Virtual assistants, freelancers and consultants** who want to set these agents up for clients as a paid service. Every agent in this book is a project you can sell.
- **Complete beginners.** If you've never used Claude or ChatGPT, Chapter 1 starts from zero.

How to use this book

- **Read Chapters 1 to 3 first.** They teach the basics, the one recipe every agent uses, and how the savings are calculated.
- **Then pick three agents, not twenty.** Chapter 10 tells you which three to start with. Build one, run it for a week, then build the next.
- **Every agent works in Claude or ChatGPT.** Where the steps differ, both are shown.
- **Fill in every [bracket]** before you paste a template. The more specific you are, the better the agent works.
- **Then find your own.** The bonus chapter shows you how to find agent number 21 and beyond, in your business or a client's.
- **Use the savings calculator.** The spreadsheet that comes with this book lets you plug in your own hours and rates for every agent.

The one rule

Agents draft. People approve. Nothing an agent writes goes to a customer, a bank, a public page or an employee until a person has read it. You can loosen that rule for one agent at a time once it has earned your trust (Chapter 10 shows how), but you start every agent on a short leash.

Chapter 1: AI basics in 30 minutes

If you already use Claude or ChatGPT every day, skim this chapter for the settings in Step 4, then move on.

What these tools actually are

Claude (made by Anthropic) and ChatGPT (made by OpenAI) are AI assistants. You type a request in plain English, and they read, write, summarize, analyze and research for you. They can work with files you upload, and with apps you connect, like your email, calendar and Google Drive.

They are very good at first drafts, summaries, sorting, checklists and turning messy notes into clean documents. They are not good at knowing facts about your business that you haven't told them, and they sometimes state wrong things with total confidence. That's why every agent in this book is built around two habits: give it your real information, and check what it produces.

Step 1: Pick one tool and one plan

You only need one. Both cost the same for an individual, and every agent in this book works in either.

	Claude	ChatGPT
Free plan	Yes, with limits	Yes, with limits
Plan you need	Pro, \$20/month	Plus, \$20/month
Projects (where agents live)	Yes	Yes
Scheduled tasks	Pro and above	Plus allows 5 active at once; Pro allows 15
Connect email, calendar, Drive	Yes (Connectors)	Yes (Apps)
Good to know	Scheduled tasks run in the cloud, so your computer can be off	Event triggers can start a task when a Gmail or Slack message arrives

Prices and limits as of October 2026. Check claude.com/pricing and chatgpt.com/pricing before you buy; both change often.

Which should you choose? If your team already uses one, use that one. If you're starting fresh, pick the one whose writing you like better: give both free plans the same request (Step 3 has a good one) and compare. For a team of two or more sharing agents, look at Claude Team or ChatGPT Business, which add shared workspaces and admin controls and keep your data out of model training by default.

One tip for ChatGPT users: you may see guides telling you to build "custom GPTs." OpenAI has announced it is retiring custom GPTs on December 11, 2026 and replacing them with plugins. Build your agents as **Projects** and **scheduled tasks** as this book shows, and you won't have to rebuild them.

Step 2: Create your account and look around

1. Go to **claude.ai** or **chatgpt.com** and sign up with your work email.
2. Install the desktop app and the phone app. You'll review agent output from your phone more than you think.
3. Find these four things in the left sidebar. You'll use all of them: - **New chat:** a blank conversation. - **Projects:** folders that hold instructions and files. Every agent in this book is a project. - **Scheduled:** where recurring tasks live. (In Claude, you'll find this under **Cowork**, or you can simply ask for a schedule in any chat.) - **Settings:** where you connect your apps and control your privacy.

Step 3: Learn to write a good request

Most bad AI output comes from a vague request. A good request has five parts. Remember them as **Role, Task, Context, Format, Rules**.

Prompt: The five-part request

Role: You are an experienced office manager for a [type of business].

Task: Write a polite reminder email to a client whose invoice is 14 days overdue.

Context: The client is [name], the invoice is [number] for \$[amount], due [date]. They've been a good client for two years and have never paid late before.

Format: Subject line plus an email under 100 words.

Rules: Warm, not apologetic. Don't threaten late fees. Include a link placeholder [PAYMENT LINK].

Send that, then practice the most important skill in AI: **talking back**. Reply with "shorter," "less formal," "add a line offering a payment plan," or "give me three versions." The first answer is a draft. The third answer is usually the one you use.

Step 4: Set up your account properly

Spend ten minutes on this before you build any agent.

1. **Privacy.** In Claude, go to **Settings > Privacy**. In ChatGPT, go to **Settings > Data controls**. Decide whether you allow your chats to be used to improve the models, and turn that off if you'll be

handling client or customer information. Business and team plans exclude your data from training by default.

2. **Tell it about you.** In Claude, use **Settings > Profile** (personal preferences). In ChatGPT, use **Settings > Personalization > Custom instructions**. Write three or four lines: what your business does, who your customers are, and how you like answers (for example, "short, plain English, no jargon, bullet points over paragraphs").
3. **Connect your core apps.** In Claude, go to **Settings > Connectors**. In ChatGPT, go to **Settings > Apps**. Connect your email, calendar and file storage (Google Workspace or Microsoft 365). Each one asks you to sign in and approve access. Connect only what you need now; Chapter 2 explains which agents need which apps.
4. **Notifications.** Turn on notifications in the phone app so you hear when a scheduled task finishes.

Step 5: Know what never to paste in

Even with training turned off, treat an AI tool like a capable new hire you met last week. Don't paste passwords, full card or bank account numbers, Social Security numbers, or medical details. When an agent needs customer data, give it the minimum: names and amounts, not full records. If you're in a regulated field (healthcare, legal, financial advice), check your rules before connecting client systems.

Your move

Sign up, choose your plan, do the four settings in Step 4, and send the five-part request above with your own details. Then talk back to it three times. That's the whole skill. Everything else in this book is that skill, saved and scheduled.

Chapter 2: The agent recipe

In this book, an **agent** is a simple thing: a project with a job description, the files it needs, access to the right apps, and (for recurring work) a schedule. Every one of the 20 agents is built from the same four parts.

Part	What it is	Human equivalent
Project	One home for one job, with its own chat history	A desk
Instructions	Standing rules the agent reads before every request	A job description
Files	Your price list, FAQ, templates, past examples	The training binder
Schedule	A saved prompt that runs on its own, hourly to weekly	The recurring calendar

Connected apps (email, calendar, Drive, accounting) are the fifth ingredient for the agents that need them.

How to build an agent in Claude

1. In the left sidebar, click **Projects**, then **Create project** (or **New project**).
2. Give it the agent's name, like "Inbox Triage Agent," and a one-line description.
3. Open the project's **Instructions** (sometimes shown as "Set project instructions") and paste the instructions from this book, with your brackets filled in.
4. Under **Files** (sometimes "Project knowledge"), click **+** and upload the files listed for that agent.
5. Start a chat inside the project and give it a small real task to test it.

How to build an agent in ChatGPT

1. In the left sidebar, click **New project**.
2. Name it after the agent.
3. Open the project's menu (...), choose **Project settings** or **Instructions**, and paste the instructions.
4. Click **Add files** and upload the files listed for that agent.
5. Start a chat inside the project and test it with a small real task.

Menus get renamed often. If a button isn't exactly where this book says, look for the same word nearby, or ask the assistant itself: "Where do I add instructions to a project?"

How to put an agent on a schedule

An on-demand agent waits for you. A **scheduled** agent does its job at a set time and leaves the result for you to review. This is where the real savings come from, because you stop having to remember to ask.

In Claude: open **Cowork**, click **Scheduled** in the sidebar, then **New task**. Choose **Create with Claude** and describe the job and when it should run, or **Set up manually** and paste the task prompt from this book, then choose the frequency (hourly, daily, weekdays or weekly). You can also just type in any chat: "Every weekday at 7:30am, do the following..." and Claude will propose a scheduled task for you to approve. Tasks run in the cloud, so your computer can be closed. They can use your connectors and the files saved to your Claude account.

In ChatGPT: open **Scheduled** in the sidebar and create a task, or type in any chat: "Every weekday at 7:30am, do the following..." ChatGPT shows a confirmation card when the task is set. Two limits to plan around: Plus allows **5 active scheduled tasks** at once, and a task created inside a project **can't read that project's uploaded files**. So for ChatGPT, make every scheduled prompt self-contained (the task prompts in this book are written that way) and keep reference documents in a connected Google Drive or OneDrive folder.

For both: the shortest interval is once an hour. Set times a few minutes past the hour (7:10, not 7:00), since on-the-hour runs can start late. Run each new task once by hand before you trust the schedule.

Write task prompts that run without you

A scheduled task runs while nobody is there to answer a question. Every task prompt in this book follows this shape, and yours should too.

Template: Scheduled task prompt

Job: [one sentence: what to produce].

Read: [which app, folder or file], covering [time window, e.g., the last 24 hours].

Steps: [3 to 6 numbered steps].

Deliver: [what to produce and where: a summary in this chat, a draft email, a file in a folder].

Never: send anything to customers, change or delete any record, or make a payment. If something you need is missing, say exactly what's missing and stop.

Your move

Build a practice agent before you build a real one. Create a project called "Practice Agent," paste the five-part request from Chapter 1 as its instructions, and use it three times. Then schedule a harmless

task: "Every weekday at 8:10am, give me a three-line summary of [an industry news topic] from the last 24 hours." When it shows up tomorrow, you know the plumbing works.

Chapter 3: How to measure what an agent saves

Every agent in this book has a **savings box**. Here's exactly how the numbers are calculated, so you can trust them and adjust them for your business.

The formula

Savings math

Hours saved per month = (minutes the task takes by hand – minutes it takes to review the agent's work) × times per month ÷ 60

Monthly savings = hours saved per month × hourly cost

Net savings = monthly savings – tool cost

The assumptions behind every estimate

- **Hourly cost: what the person who'd normally do the job costs.** Each agent is priced at the national median pay for that role from the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (May 2025), plus benefits and payroll taxes. Wages are 70% of what private employers spend on a worker (BLS, June 2026), so the loaded rate is the median wage ÷ 0.70. The table below lists every rate. If you do the work yourself as the owner, your time is almost certainly worth more. Change any rate in the calculator.
- **A month is 20 workdays or 4 weeks.** That's slightly short on purpose, so the numbers stay conservative.
- **Review time is counted.** Every estimate subtracts the time a person spends checking the agent's work. An agent that saves 30 minutes but takes 25 to check isn't worth building, and you won't find one in this book.
- **Volumes are for a typical small business** of 3 to 20 people. If you send twice as many invoices or answer twice as many tickets, your savings roughly double.
- **Cash and revenue gains are listed separately and never added in.** Getting paid ten days sooner or winning one more proposal is real money, but it's harder to promise, so it sits under "Upside" and stays out of the totals.
- **Tool cost:** one \$20/month plan runs every agent in this book for one person. Heavy use or a team plan costs more; subtract your real bill.

The hourly rates used in this book

Role	Agents	Median pay (BLS)	With benefits
Customer service representative	11, 12, 14	\$21.53	\$31
Bill and account collector	15	\$22.61	\$32
Bookkeeping clerk	16, 18	\$24.36	\$35
Human resources specialist	19	\$36.51	\$52
Sales representative	5, 6, 7	\$36.76	\$53
Executive assistant	1, 2	\$36.82	\$53
Writer	9	\$36.98	\$53
Marketing specialist or market research analyst	8, 10, 13	\$37.87	\$54
Accountant	17	\$40.23	\$57
Technical writer	3	\$43.46	\$62
Management analyst	4	\$48.97	\$70
General and operations manager	20	\$50.85	\$73

Median hourly pay from the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics, May 2025 (executive assistant and operations manager converted from annual pay at 2,080 hours). "With benefits" divides by 0.70, because wages were 70% of private employers' total compensation costs in June 2026 (BLS Employer Costs for Employee Compensation). Rates in your city may be higher or lower; a freelancer or VA may charge more or less.

What all 20 add up to

If a typical small business built all 20 agents, the conservative total is about **110 hours and \$5,660 a month**, or roughly **\$68,000 a year**, before any cash or revenue upside. That's more than a part-time employee's worth of hours, for the price of a software subscription.

You won't build all 20, and you shouldn't try. The point of the number is this: even the three best-fit agents for your business are likely to save \$1,000 to \$1,400 a month. The full table is in Chapter 10.

Measure your own savings

Estimates are a starting point. Before you build an agent, time the task by hand once and write it down. After the agent has run for two weeks, time your review. Put both numbers in the calculator.

That's the figure to quote to your boss, your partner, or your client.

Chapter 4: Operations agents

Operations is where most of the hidden hours live: email, meetings, documentation and reporting. These four agents usually pay back the fastest.

Agent 1: The Inbox Triage Agent

Runs: every weekday morning · **Needs:** email connector (Gmail or Outlook) · **Setup time:** 30 minutes

What it does: Reads the last day's email, sorts it into "needs you," "can wait," and "ignore," and drafts replies to the routine messages so your first hour isn't spent in your inbox.

Savings math

Before: 45 minutes a day reading, sorting and answering routine email. After: 15 minutes reviewing the summary and sending drafts.

30 minutes × 20 workdays = **10 hours a month × \$53 = \$530/month** (\$6,360/year)

Rate: **\$53/hour**, the cost of an executive assistant: median pay of \$36.82/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Inbox Triage Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Inbox Triage Agent

You manage the inbox for [your name], [your role] at [business], which [one line on what the business does].

Sort every email into: (1) Needs [name] today: anything from a client, a deadline, money, or a decision. (2) Can wait: internal updates, vendors, scheduling. (3) Ignore: newsletters, promotions, notifications.

Always flag: [your 3 to 5 VIP senders or keywords, e.g., "anything from Acme Corp," "refund," "contract"].

For routine emails, draft a reply using my voice: [3 rules, e.g., friendly, short, sign off "Best, Sam"]. Use the answers in the FAQ file. If you don't know the answer, write "[NEEDS ANSWER]" in the draft rather than guessing.

Never send anything. Drafts only.

3. Upload: your FAQ or a list of common questions and answers, and three emails you've written that sound like you.

4. Connect: your email account (Gmail or Outlook). In Claude, also enable your calendar so it can answer "are you free Thursday?" emails.

Put it on a schedule

Scheduled task: Morning inbox sweep · Weekdays, 7:10am

Job: Triage my inbox and draft routine replies. **Read:** emails received in the last 24 hours (72 hours on Mondays). **Steps:** (1) Sort into Needs me today, Can wait, Ignore. (2) Flag anything from [VIP list] or about money, contracts or deadlines. (3) For each routine email, create a draft reply in my email drafts folder, short and friendly, signed "[sign-off]." Mark anything you're unsure of "[NEEDS ANSWER]."

Deliver: a summary with the Needs me today list first, one line each, with who, what and the deadline.

Never send an email, delete anything, or reply to anyone about money.

Check it: For the first week, read every draft before sending. Note what you change, and add a rule to the instructions each time you fix the same thing twice. If your email connector can't create drafts in your account, ask the agent to put the draft replies in the summary instead.

Agent 2: The Meeting Notes Agent

Runs: after every meeting (on demand) · **Needs:** a meeting transcript (Zoom, Teams, Google Meet or any note-taking app) ·

Setup time: 20 minutes

What it does: Turns a raw meeting transcript into clean notes, decisions, a task list with owners and dates, and a ready-to-send follow-up email.

Savings math

Before: 20 minutes after each meeting writing notes and the follow-up. After: 5 minutes to paste the transcript and check the output.

15 minutes × 24 meetings a month = **6 hours a month × \$53 = \$318/month** (\$3,816/year)

Rate: **\$53/hour**, the cost of an executive assistant: median pay of \$36.82/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): fewer dropped tasks because every meeting ends with a written list.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Meeting Notes Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Meeting Notes Agent

When I paste a meeting transcript or rough notes, produce:

1. **Summary:** 3 to 5 bullets on what was discussed.
2. **Decisions:** each decision in one line. If none were made, say so.
3. **Action items:** a table with Task, Owner, Due date. If an owner or date wasn't said, write "UNASSIGNED" or "NO DATE" rather than guessing.
4. **Open questions:** anything left unresolved.
5. **Follow-up email:** to the attendees, under 150 words, listing decisions and action items.

Our team: [names and roles, so you can match first names to people]. Our clients: [key client names].

Keep my voice: [2 to 3 rules].

3. Upload: a short team list and, if you have one, a past meeting summary you liked.

4. Connect: nothing required. If your notes live in Google Drive or your note-taker saves to Drive, connect it so you can say "summarize today's 2pm call."

Use it: Turn on your video tool's transcript or recording feature (Zoom, Teams and Meet all have one). After the call, paste the transcript into the project and say "Notes for this one."

Check it: Read the action items twice. That's where errors cost money. Never let it invent a due date.

Agent 3: The SOP Writer Agent

Runs: on demand, about twice a month · **Needs:** nothing · **Setup time:** 20 minutes

What it does: Turns a messy explanation of how a task is done (a voice note, a recorded walkthrough, or bullet points) into a clean step-by-step standard operating procedure your team or your other agents can follow.

Savings math

Before: about 4 hours to write and format one SOP. After: 1 hour to talk it through and review.

3 hours × 2 SOPs a month = **6 hours a month × \$62 = \$372/month** (\$4,464/year)

Rate: **\$62/hour**, the cost of a technical writer: median pay of \$43.46/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): faster training for new hires, and every SOP you write becomes instructions for another agent.

Build it

1. Create a project called "SOP Writer Agent."

2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: SOP Writer Agent

You turn rough explanations into standard operating procedures for [business]. Every SOP uses this format:

Title · **Purpose** (one sentence) · **Owner** (role, not name) · **When it runs** · **Tools needed** · **Steps** (numbered, one action per step, starting with a verb) · **Quality check** (how to know it was done right) · **Common mistakes** · **Last updated** (today's date).

Write for someone on their first week. If a step is unclear or missing in what I gave you, list your questions at the end under "Gaps to fill" instead of guessing.

3. Upload: one existing SOP or checklist you like, if you have one.

Use it: Record yourself doing the task while you talk it through (your phone's voice memo, or a screen recording tool like Loom). Paste the transcript into the project: "Make this an SOP." Answer its "Gaps to fill" questions, and ask for the final version.

Check it: Have the person who'll actually do the task follow the SOP once without your help. Every question they ask is a missing step.

Agent 4: The Weekly Operations Report Agent

Runs: every Monday morning · **Needs:** Google Drive, OneDrive or your spreadsheet tool · **Setup time:** 45 minutes

What it does: Pulls the numbers you track each week (sales, leads, open jobs, tickets, cash), compares them to last week and to your targets, and writes a one-page report with what changed and what needs attention.

Savings math

Before: about 3 hours every week gathering numbers and writing the update. After: 30 minutes reviewing and adding your judgment.

2.5 hours × 4 weeks = **10 hours a month × \$70 = \$700/month** (\$8,400/year)

Rate: **\$70/hour**, the cost of a management analyst: median pay of \$48.97/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Weekly Ops Report Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Weekly Ops Report Agent

You write the weekly operations report for [business]. Our key numbers and targets: [list 5 to 8, e.g., "New leads (target 25/week)," "Jobs completed (target 12/week)," "Cash in bank (minimum \$30,000)," "Open support tickets (under 10)"]].

The report is one page: **Headline** (one sentence on how the week went) · **Scorecard** (table: metric, this week, last week, target, status green/yellow/red) · **What changed and why** (3 bullets) · **Needs attention** (anything red, with a suggested next step) · **Data problems** (any number that was missing or looked wrong).

Only use numbers from the source files. Never estimate or fill a gap. Show every calculation you make.

3. Upload: last month's reports if you have them, so it learns the format.
4. Connect: Google Drive or OneDrive. Keep one spreadsheet, the "weekly scorecard," where you or your team enter the numbers each Friday.

Put it on a schedule

Scheduled task: Monday ops report · Weekly, Monday 7:10am

Job: Write the weekly operations report. **Read:** the "[Weekly Scorecard]" spreadsheet in [Drive folder], this week's and last week's columns. **Steps:** (1) Pull each metric for this week and last week. (2) Compare to these targets: [paste targets]. (3) Mark each metric green (on target), yellow (within 10%), or red. (4) Write the one-page report: headline, scorecard table, what changed, needs attention, data problems. **Deliver:** the report in this chat, ready to paste into email. **Never** change the spreadsheet. If the sheet hasn't been updated this week, say so and stop.

Check it: Spot-check three numbers against the sheet every week for the first month. A report with one wrong number is worse than no report.

Chapter 5: Sales agents

Sales agents do the research and the remembering, which is where most deals are quietly lost. You still have the conversations.

Agent 5: The Prospect Research Agent

Runs: on demand, before outreach or calls · **Needs:** web search (built in) · **Setup time:** 20 minutes

What it does: Researches a company or person from their website and public information, and gives you a one-page brief: what they do, likely problems you can solve, a personalized opening line, and questions to ask.

Savings math

Before: 20 minutes researching each prospect. After: 5 minutes reading the brief and checking one fact.

15 minutes × 20 prospects a month = **5 hours a month × \$53 = \$265/month** (\$3,180/year)

Rate: **\$53/hour**, the cost of a sales representative: median pay of \$36.76/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): better-researched outreach gets more replies.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Prospect Research Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Prospect Research Agent

I sell [your service] to [ideal client]. The problems I solve best are [2 to 3 problems]. When I give you a company name, website or person, research them using public sources and write a brief:

Snapshot: what they do, size, location, recent news (with links). · **Likely problems I can solve:** 2 to 3, each tied to something you actually found. · **Fit score:** 1 to 5, with one sentence why. · **Opening line:** one personalized first sentence for an email, referencing something specific and true. · **Discovery questions:** 3.

Link every fact to its source. If you can't verify something, say "unverified." Never invent news, names or numbers.

3. Upload: your one-page description of your offer and your ideal client.

Use it: "Research [company website]." For a batch: "Research these five and rank them by fit."

Check it: Click one source link per brief. If a fact doesn't check out, tell the agent and add "verify every fact against the linked page" to its instructions.

Agent 6: The Follow-Up Agent

Runs: every weekday morning · **Needs:** your CRM or a pipeline spreadsheet (in Drive or OneDrive), plus email · **Setup time:** 40 minutes

What it does: Checks your pipeline every morning, finds every lead, proposal and past client who is due a follow-up, and drafts each message so nothing slips through the cracks.

Savings math

Before: 30 minutes a day checking the pipeline and writing follow-ups. After: about 12 minutes reviewing and sending drafts.

18 minutes × 20 workdays = **6 hours a month × \$53 = \$318/month** (\$3,816/year)

Rate: **\$53/hour**, the cost of a sales representative: median pay of \$36.76/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): most sales need several follow-ups and most people stop after one. If consistent follow-up wins one extra \$2,000 client a quarter, that's about \$670 a month more.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Follow-Up Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Follow-Up Agent

You manage follow-ups for [business]. Our pipeline is in [CRM name or "the Pipeline spreadsheet"], with columns for name, company, stage, last contact date, and next step.

Follow-up rules: new lead with no reply: follow up after 3 days, then 7, then 14, then a polite close.

Proposal sent: follow up after 2 days, then 5, then 10. Past client: check in every 90 days.

Every follow-up must add something: a useful idea, a short answer to a likely question, or a relevant example. Never write "just checking in" or "bumping this to the top of your inbox."

Voice: [3 rules]. Under 90 words. Never send. Drafts only.

3. Upload: two or three follow-up emails that worked for you, and a list of useful resources you can share (articles, case studies, checklists).
4. Connect: Google Drive or OneDrive (for the pipeline spreadsheet) or your CRM if a connector exists for it, and your email.

Put it on a schedule

Scheduled task: Daily follow-ups · Weekdays, 8:10am

Job: Draft today's follow-ups. **Read:** the "[Pipeline]" spreadsheet in [folder]. **Steps:** (1) Find every row whose next follow-up date is today or earlier, using these rules: [paste follow-up rules]. (2) For each, draft a follow-up under 90 words that adds one useful idea, signed "[sign-off]". (3) Put the drafts in my email drafts folder. **Deliver:** a list of who's due, the stage, and a one-line summary of each draft. **Never** send email or change the spreadsheet. If the sheet can't be read, say so and stop.

Check it: Update the "last contact" date in your sheet when you send. If you skip that, the agent will draft the same follow-up again tomorrow. (Five minutes of discipline here is the whole system.)

Agent 7: The Proposal Builder Agent

Runs: on demand, after discovery calls · **Needs:** your call notes · **Setup time:** 45 minutes

What it does: Turns your discovery call notes into a clear one-page proposal in your format, with scope, timeline, price options and next steps.

Savings math

Before: about 3 hours to write a proposal. After: 1 hour to review, adjust pricing and polish.

2 hours × 4 proposals a month = **8 hours a month × \$53 = \$424/month** (\$5,088/year)

Rate: **\$53/hour**, the cost of a sales representative: median pay of \$36.76/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): proposals that go out the same day close more often than ones that take a week.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Proposal Builder Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Proposal Builder Agent

You write proposals for [business]. Our services and prices are in the "Services and pricing" file. Use only those prices.

Every proposal has: **Their situation** (in their words, from the call notes) · **The result they want** · **What we'll do** (scope, as a short list) · **What's not included** · **Timeline** · **Investment** (three options when it makes sense: starter, recommended, premium; mark the recommended one) · **Next step** (one clear action and date).

One page. Plain English. If the notes don't tell you their budget, timeline or decision-maker, list those as questions for me before writing.

3. Upload: your services and pricing sheet, your two best past proposals, and a short list of past results you're allowed to mention.

4. Connect: optional. Google Drive, if you'd like it to pull call notes from the Meeting Notes Agent.

Use it: "Here are my notes from the call with [name]. Write the proposal." Then: "Make the recommended option clearer" or "Turn this into an email version."

Check it: You own the price. Read the investment section line by line every time.

Chapter 6: Marketing agents

Marketing is the most repetitive creative work in a business: the same ideas, reshaped for every channel, every week. Agents do the reshaping. You supply the ideas and the taste.

Agent 8: The Content Repurposing Agent

Runs: on demand, once a week · **Needs:** one piece of content (a video transcript, blog post, podcast or long post) · **Setup time:** 30 minutes

What it does: Takes one piece of content and turns it into a week of posts: LinkedIn, Instagram captions, a short email, a few short-form video scripts, all in your voice.

Savings math

Before: about 3 hours to write a week of posts from scratch. After: 45 minutes to edit and schedule.

2.25 hours × 4 weeks = **9 hours a month × \$54 = \$486/month** (\$5,832/year)

Rate: **\$54/hour**, the cost of a marketing specialist: median pay of \$37.87/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Content Repurposing Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Content Repurposing Agent

You turn one piece of content into a week of posts for [business], which serves [audience]. Our voice: [3 to 5 rules, e.g., practical, warm, no hype, no emojis except one per post].

From each piece, produce: **3 LinkedIn posts** (under 200 words, one idea each, hook in the first line, no hashtags in the body) · **3 Instagram or Facebook captions** · **2 short video scripts** (30 to 45 seconds, hook, three points, call to action) · **1 email** (under 200 words, one link) · **5 headline options** for the original.

Use only ideas and facts from the source. Don't invent statistics or client stories.

3. Upload: 5 to 10 of your best past posts, so it learns your voice.

Use it: Paste a transcript or article: "Repurpose this for next week."

Check it: Read every post out loud. Cut any sentence you wouldn't say to a client's face.

Agent 9: The Newsletter Agent

Runs: every week · **Needs:** a notes doc in Drive or OneDrive (optional) · **Setup time:** 30 minutes

What it does: Drafts your weekly email newsletter from your notes, recent wins and the content you published that week, in a consistent format.

Savings math

Before: about 3 hours to write and format a newsletter. After: 1 hour to edit and send.

2 hours × 4 weeks = **8 hours a month × \$53 = \$424/month** (\$5,088/year)

Rate: **\$53/hour**, the cost of a writer: median pay of \$36.98/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): a newsletter that goes out every single week keeps you top of mind, which is where repeat and referral business comes from.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Newsletter Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Newsletter Agent

You draft the weekly newsletter for [business]. Readers are [audience] and they want [what they value: practical tips, local news, industry updates].

Format: subject line (3 options, under 50 characters) · opening (2 to 3 sentences, personal) · **one main idea** (150 to 250 words, practical, one takeaway) · **quick hits** (3 short bullets with links) · **one call to action** ([your offer, booking link or reply prompt]) · sign-off "[name]."

Use only material from my notes and the links I give you. Mark anything you're unsure of with [CHECK].

3. Upload: your three best past newsletters.
4. Connect: Google Drive or OneDrive, with a doc called "Newsletter notes" where you drop ideas during the week.

Put it on a schedule

Scheduled task: Newsletter draft · Weekly, Wednesday 9:10am

Job: Draft this week's newsletter. **Read:** the "Newsletter notes" doc in [folder], items added in the last 7 days. **Steps:** (1) Pick the strongest idea as the main piece. (2) Pick three other items as quick hits. (3) Write the newsletter in our format: [paste format]. **Deliver:** the full draft here, with 3 subject lines.

Never send or schedule anything in our email platform. If the notes doc is empty, give me 3 topic ideas for [audience] instead.

Check it: You send it, from your email platform, after reading it. Always.

Agent 10: The Competitor Watch Agent

Runs: every Monday · **Needs:** web search (built in) · **Setup time:** 20 minutes

What it does: Checks your competitors' websites, pricing pages and news every week, and tells you only what changed and whether it matters.

Savings math

Before: about 4 hours a month checking competitors (or, more honestly, not doing it at all). After: 30 minutes reading the weekly briefs.

3.5 hours a month × \$54 = \$189/month (\$2,268/year)

Rate: **\$54/hour**, the cost of a market research analyst: median pay of \$37.87/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): spotting a competitor's price increase or new offer weeks earlier.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Competitor Watch Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Competitor Watch Agent

You track competitors for [business]. Our competitors: [name and website for 3 to 5]. Our prices: [summary].

Each week, check each competitor's website, pricing page, blog and news. Report only **changes**: new offers, price changes, new hires or locations, big announcements, notable reviews. For each change: what happened (with a link), and whether it matters to us (yes / maybe / no, with one sentence). If nothing changed, say "No changes" for that competitor. Never guess at prices you can't see.

Put it on a schedule

Scheduled task: Weekly competitor brief · Weekly, Monday 8:10am

Job: Brief me on competitor changes in the last 7 days. **Read:** the websites and recent news for [list competitors and URLs]. **Steps:** (1) Check each site's homepage, pricing and blog. (2) Search news from the last 7 days. (3) List changes with links. (4) Rate each change: matters / maybe / doesn't.

Deliver: a one-screen brief, most important change first. **Never** contact any competitor or fill in a form.

Check it: Click the link on anything marked "matters" before you act on it.

Agent 11: The Review Reply Agent

Runs: every week · **Needs:** your review notifications (by email) · **Setup time:** 20 minutes

What it does: Drafts a thoughtful, personal reply to every new online review, and flags unhappy customers so someone can reach out the same day.

Savings math

Before: about 9 minutes per review to read, think and reply. After: 3 minutes to review and post.

6 minutes × 25 reviews a month = **2.5 hours a month × \$31 = \$78/month** (\$936/year)

Rate: **\$31/hour**, the cost of a customer service representative: median pay of \$21.53/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): businesses that reply to reviews look more trustworthy to the next customer, and a fast response to a bad review can save the customer.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Review Reply Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Review Reply Agent

You draft replies to online reviews for [business]. Our voice: [2 to 3 rules].

5-star and 4-star: thank them by first name, mention one specific thing they said, invite them back. Under 50 words. Vary the wording; never use the same opening twice in a row.

3 stars or below: thank them, acknowledge the specific problem without arguing or admitting legal fault, and invite them to contact [name, email or phone] directly. Under 60 words. Flag it as **URGENT** at the top of your output so we reach out today.

Never offer refunds, discounts or compensation in a public reply. Never share any customer details.

3. Connect: your email, if review notifications from Google, Yelp, Facebook or your industry site arrive there.

Put it on a schedule

Scheduled task: Weekly review replies · Weekly, Friday 10:10am

Job: Draft replies to new reviews. **Read:** review notification emails from [Google / Yelp / other] in the last 7 days. **Steps:** (1) List each review with platform, stars and reviewer first name. (2) Draft a reply following these rules: [paste rules]. (3) Put any 3-star-or-lower review at the top marked URGENT.

Deliver: a list of reviews with draft replies, ready to copy and paste. **Never** post a reply yourself.

Check it: For any negative review, call or email the customer before you post the public reply.

Chapter 7: Customer service agents

Service agents work from your knowledge, so they're only as good as the FAQ and policies you give them. Building them forces you to write those down, which is worth doing anyway.

Agent 12: The Support Reply Agent

Runs: on demand, or hourly during business hours · **Needs:** your support email or helpdesk · **Setup time:** 1 hour (most of it writing your FAQ)

What it does: Drafts accurate replies to customer questions using your own FAQ, policies and product information, so your team edits instead of writing from scratch.

Savings math

Before: about 8 minutes to research and write each reply. After: 3 minutes to check and send.

5 minutes × 96 tickets a month (about 24 a week) = **8 hours a month × \$31 = \$248/month**
(\$2,976/year)

Rate: **\$31/hour**, the cost of a customer service representative: median pay of \$21.53/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): faster replies mean happier customers and fewer "just following up on my email" messages.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Support Reply Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Support Reply Agent

You draft replies to customer emails for [business]. Answer **only** from the uploaded FAQ, policies and product files. Our voice: [rules, e.g., warm, clear, first name, no corporate phrases].

For every message: (1) identify what the customer is asking, (2) find the answer in our files, (3) draft a reply under 120 words that answers it and tells them what happens next.

If the answer isn't in our files, don't guess. Write "ESCALATE" and say what's missing. Always escalate: refunds over \$[amount], complaints about a staff member, legal or safety issues, and angry customers who've written more than once.

Never promise a delivery date, refund or exception that isn't in our policies.

3. Upload: your FAQ, return or refund policy, shipping or service terms, price list, and 10 good past replies.

4. Connect: your support email account or helpdesk if a connector is available.

Put it on a schedule (optional)

Scheduled task: Support drafts · Hourly, weekdays 9am to 5pm (or daily at 8:10am for lower volume)

Job: Draft replies to new support emails. **Read:** unanswered emails in [support inbox or label] from the last hour. **Steps:** (1) For each, find the answer in our FAQ and policies: [paste or link the FAQ]. (2) Draft a reply under 120 words in my email drafts folder. (3) Mark anything you can't answer as ESCALATE.

Deliver: a list: customer, question, drafted or escalated. **Never** send a reply or promise a refund.

Check it: Every "ESCALATE" is a gap in your FAQ. Once a week, add the answers, and the agent gets better on its own.

Agent 13: The Customer Feedback Analyzer

Runs: monthly · **Needs:** a survey export, support emails or reviews · **Setup time:** 20 minutes

What it does: Reads a month of feedback (surveys, reviews, support emails, cancellation reasons) and tells you the top themes, how often each came up, and what to fix first.

Savings math

Before: about 4 hours a month reading and tallying feedback, if anyone does it at all. After: 30 minutes reading the report.

3.5 hours a month × \$54 = \$189/month (\$2,268/year)

Rate: **\$54/hour**, the cost of a market research analyst: median pay of \$37.87/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): fixing the number-one complaint is usually the cheapest way to keep customers. Keeping even one \$100/month customer who would have left is \$1,200 a year.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Feedback Analyzer."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Feedback Analyzer

You analyze customer feedback for [business]. When I give you survey results, reviews, support emails or cancellation reasons:

1. Group the comments into themes.
2. Count how many comments fall under each theme.
3. Quote 2 short real examples per theme.
4. Separate praise from problems.
5. Recommend the **top 3 fixes**, ranked by how often the issue comes up and how much it likely costs us.

Report counts exactly. Don't round "4 out of 60" into "many customers." Remove customer names from quotes.

Put it on a schedule

Scheduled task: Monthly feedback report · Monthly, first weekday at 9:10am (choose weekly in the menu if monthly isn't offered, and ask the assistant to change it to the first of the month)

Job: Summarize last month's customer feedback. **Read:** [the feedback folder in Drive / survey results file / emails labeled "Feedback"] from the last month. **Steps:** group into themes, count each, quote examples, recommend the top 3 fixes. **Deliver:** a one-page report. **Never** contact customers.

Check it: Read the raw comments behind the top theme. The count is the agent's job; the judgment is yours.

Agent 14: The Client Onboarding Agent

Runs: each time you sign a new client or customer · **Needs:** your onboarding checklist · **Setup time:** 45 minutes

What it does: For each new client, produces a personalized welcome email, a kickoff checklist, the questions to ask before you start, and a reminder schedule for the first 30 days.

Savings math

Before: about 2 hours of setup and emails per new client. After: 30 minutes to review and send.

1.5 hours × 4 new clients a month = **6 hours a month × \$31 = \$186/month** (\$2,232/year)

Rate: **\$31/hour**, the cost of a customer service representative: median pay of \$21.53/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): clients who get a smooth first week stay longer and refer more.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Client Onboarding Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Client Onboarding Agent

You prepare onboarding for each new client of [business]. When I give you the client's name, what they bought, start date and any notes, produce:

1. **Welcome email:** warm, under 150 words, what happens next, what we need from them, and when.
2. **Intake questions:** the questions we need answered before we start (from the intake template), plus any specific to their situation.
3. **Kickoff checklist:** internal steps with owners, from our onboarding SOP.
4. **First 30 days:** a schedule of check-ins and reminders with draft messages.

Use our standard timeline and terms from the files. Never change what's included in what they bought.

3. Upload: your onboarding checklist or SOP (the SOP Writer Agent can make one), your intake questions, your welcome packet, and your services list.

Use it: "New client: [name], bought [package], starts [date]. Notes: [anything special]."

Check it: Confirm the welcome email matches exactly what the client bought. That's the line that causes billing disputes later.

Chapter 8: Finance agents

Finance agents handle the numbers work most owners put off. The rule here is stricter than anywhere else: **finance agents prepare, people approve**. No agent in this chapter moves money, sends an invoice, or changes your books on its own.

Agent 15: The Collections Agent

Runs: every Monday · **Needs:** your accounting software's receivables report (QuickBooks, Xero or a spreadsheet) and email · **Setup time:** 40 minutes

What it does: Checks who owes you money every week and drafts the right reminder for each overdue invoice: friendly at 7 days, firmer at 30, a call script at 45.

Savings math

Before: about 4 hours a month checking receivables and writing reminders. After: 1 hour reviewing and sending.

3 hours a month × \$32 = \$96/month (\$1,152/year)

Rate: **\$32/hour**, the cost of a bill and account collector: median pay of \$22.61/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted, and usually much bigger): if you have \$20,000 in open invoices and consistent reminders get them paid 10 days sooner, you have that cash in hand when you need it, and fewer invoices become write-offs.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Collections Agent."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Collections Agent

You prepare payment reminders for [business]. Our payment terms: [e.g., net 15]. Payment link or method: [details].

Reminder ladder: 1 to 7 days overdue: friendly note with the invoice and payment link. 8 to 30 days: polite but direct, ask for a payment date. 31 to 45 days: firm, mention our terms, offer a payment plan if appropriate. Over 45 days: don't email; write me a short call script and flag for my decision.

Each reminder: under 100 words, invoice number, amount, original due date, how to pay. Warm and professional. Never threaten, never mention collections agencies or legal action, never add fees that aren't in our terms.

Exceptions: [clients to never auto-remind, e.g., "anyone on a payment plan," "Acme Corp: talk to me first"].

3. Upload: your payment terms and one good reminder email you've sent.
4. Connect: your accounting software if a connector is available (QuickBooks and Xero have them in some plans and regions), or export an "accounts receivable aging" report to a Drive folder each Monday. Connect email for drafts.

Put it on a schedule

Scheduled task: Monday collections · Weekly, Monday 9:10am

Job: Prepare reminders for overdue invoices. **Read:** the accounts receivable aging report from [QuickBooks / Xero / Drive folder]. **Steps:** (1) List every overdue invoice with client, amount and days overdue. (2) Skip anyone on this list: [exceptions]. (3) Draft the right reminder using this ladder: [paste ladder]. (4) Put email reminders in my drafts folder. **Deliver:** a table: client, invoice, amount, days overdue, action taken (draft or call), plus total overdue. **Never** send an email, change an invoice, or record a payment.

Check it: Before sending, make sure the invoice hasn't been paid in the last few days. A reminder for a paid invoice costs goodwill.

Agent 16: The Expense Categorizer

Runs: monthly · **Needs:** a bank or card statement export (CSV) · **Setup time:** 30 minutes

What it does: Takes your monthly bank and card transactions, sorts them into your bookkeeping categories, flags anything odd (duplicates, unusual amounts, missing receipts) and hands your bookkeeper a clean file.

Savings math

Before: about 5 hours a month categorizing transactions and chasing questions. After: 1.5 hours reviewing flagged items.

3.5 hours a month × \$35 = \$123/month (\$1,476/year)

Rate: **\$35/hour**, the cost of a bookkeeping clerk: median pay of \$24.36/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

If you pay a bookkeeper by the hour, this also shortens their bill.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Expense Categorizer."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Expense Categorizer

You prepare monthly transactions for bookkeeping at [business]. Our categories are in the "Chart of accounts" file. Known vendors and their categories are in the "Vendor list" file.

For each transaction: assign a category from our list only. If a vendor is new or ambiguous, mark it **REVIEW** with your best guess and why. Flag: possible duplicates, amounts more than double the usual for that vendor, personal-looking purchases, and anything over \$[amount].

Output: a spreadsheet with date, vendor, amount, category, confidence (high / review), and notes.

Then a summary: total by category and a list of everything flagged. Never change amounts or drop a transaction.

3. Upload: your chart of accounts (category list) and a vendor list with categories (export last year's categorized transactions; it builds this in minutes).

Use it: Download last month's statement as a CSV from your bank. Upload it: "Categorize last month."

Check it: Your bookkeeper or accountant still owns the books. This agent prepares; they post. Check the totals match your statement before you hand the file over.

Agent 17: The Monthly Financial Summary Agent

Runs: monthly, after your books close · **Needs:** profit and loss report and balance sheet · **Setup time:** 30 minutes

What it does: Turns your monthly financial reports into a plain-English one-page summary: how the month went, what changed, where the money went, and three questions worth asking.

Savings math

Before: about 4 hours a month reading reports and writing an update for partners, investors or yourself.
After: 1 hour reviewing.

3 hours a month × \$57 = \$171/month (\$2,052/year)

Rate: **\$57/hour**, the cost of an accountant: median pay of \$40.23/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Upside (not counted): owners who read their numbers monthly catch cost creep and margin slips months earlier.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Monthly Financial Summary."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Monthly Financial Summary

You explain [business]'s monthly financial reports in plain English for [the owner / partners]. When I upload the profit and loss and balance sheet:

The month in one sentence. · **Key numbers:** revenue, gross margin %, total expenses, net profit and net margin %, cash on hand, compared with last month and the same month last year if provided. ·

What changed: the 3 biggest movements, with amounts. · **Watch list:** any expense line up more than 15% from last month, and any trend over 3 months. · **3 questions to ask** my accountant or team.

Show your math for every percentage. Use only the numbers in the reports. You explain; you don't give tax, legal or investment advice.

3. Upload: last month's summary once you have one, so it keeps the same format.
4. Connect: your accounting software if a connector is available. Otherwise, export the reports as PDF or Excel and upload them.

Use it: "Here are September's P&L and balance sheet. Write the summary."

Check it: Tie net profit and cash to the reports yourself. Two numbers, thirty seconds.

Agent 18: The Subscription and Spend Auditor

Runs: quarterly · **Needs:** 3 months of bank and card statements · **Setup time:** 20 minutes

What it does: Finds every recurring charge you're paying, flags the ones nobody uses, duplicates, price increases and forgotten free trials, and drafts the cancellation or renegotiation emails.

Savings math

Time: about 2.5 hours a quarter, cut to 1. That's small. The real savings is the cancelled spend.

Example: cancelling two unused \$30/month tools saves **\$60/month**, plus about 30 minutes of a bookkeeping clerk's time a month at \$35/hour (\$18). Conservative total: **\$78/month** (\$936/year). Many businesses find far more the first time they run this.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Spend Auditor."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Spend Auditor

You audit recurring spending for [business]. From the statements I upload:

1. List every recurring charge: vendor, amount, frequency, first and latest date.
2. Flag: **duplicates** (two tools doing the same job), **price increases**, **free trials that became paid**, and anything charged to more than one card.
3. For each, ask me one question to decide keep / cancel / downgrade, using the "Who uses what" file if I've provided it.
4. For anything I mark cancel or renegotiate, draft a short email or list the cancellation steps.

Show the annual cost of every recurring charge, not just the monthly cost. Never cancel anything yourself.

3. Upload: three months of statements (CSV or PDF). Optionally, a short "Who uses what" list from your team.

Use it: Run it the first week of each quarter. Set a reminder in your calendar, or a scheduled task that simply says "Remind me to run the Spend Auditor and upload last quarter's statements."

Check it: Before cancelling, confirm with whoever owns the tool. Cancelling the one thing payroll depends on is not a saving.

Chapter 9: Hiring and team agents

People work is where judgment matters most, so these agents handle the paperwork and the questions, never the decisions.

Agent 19: The Hiring Assistant

Runs: each time you hire · **Needs:** the role description and applications · **Setup time:** 30 minutes

What it does: Writes the job post, builds a scoring rubric, summarizes each application against the rubric, and drafts interview questions and candidate emails.

Savings math

Before: about 15 hours per hire on the job post, screening 50 applications, interview guides and emails.
After: about 5 hours.

10 hours per hire × 1 hire a quarter = **about 3.3 hours a month × \$52 = \$173/month** (\$2,076/year).

Hiring more often multiplies this.

Rate: **\$52/hour**, the cost of a human resources specialist: median pay of \$36.51/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Hiring Assistant."
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Hiring Assistant

You help [business] hire. For each role:

1. **Job post:** clear title, what the person will actually do in their first 90 days, must-haves vs. nice-to-haves, pay range [always include it], how to apply. Plain English, no clichés like "rockstar" or "fast-paced environment."
2. **Scoring rubric:** 4 to 6 job-related criteria, each scored 1 to 5 with a description of what a 1, 3 and 5 looks like.
3. **Application summaries:** for each application, summarize evidence against each criterion and quote where it came from. Give a suggested score and confidence.
4. **Interview guide** and **candidate emails** (invite, decline, offer), warm and prompt.

Fairness rules: score only job-related skills and experience. Ignore and never comment on name, age, gender, race, nationality, photos, gaps in employment, or anything else unrelated to the job. You suggest; a person decides every rejection and every hire.

3. Upload: your current team's job descriptions, your pay ranges, and your company values or culture notes.

Use it: "Write the post for a [role]." Later: "Here are 20 applications. Summarize each against the rubric."

Check it: A person reads every application that scores in the middle of the range, and every rejection is a human decision. In some places (New York City, Colorado, the EU and others) there are specific rules about using AI in hiring; check yours before you use it for screening.

Agent 20: The Team Q&A Agent

Runs: on demand, for your whole team · **Needs:** your handbook, SOPs and policies · **Setup time:** 1 hour

What it does: Answers your team's everyday questions (how do I request time off, where's the template for X, what's our refund policy, how do I do Y) from your own documents, so they stop interrupting you.

Savings math

Before: about 15 questions a week to the owner or manager at 5 minutes each, plus the lost focus.

After: about 15 minutes a week handling only what the agent can't answer.

60 minutes × 4 weeks = **about 4 hours a month × \$73 = \$292/month** (\$3,504/year)

Rate: **\$73/hour**, the cost of a general and operations manager: median pay of \$50.85/hour (BLS, May 2025) plus benefits.

Build it

1. Create a project called "Team Q&A Agent." On Claude Team or ChatGPT Business, share the project with your team. On an individual plan, you can use it yourself to answer questions faster, or upgrade when the team is ready.
2. Paste these instructions:

Instructions: Team Q&A Agent

You answer questions from [business]'s team using **only** our uploaded handbook, SOPs, policies and templates. Answer in plain language, under 120 words, and name the document and section you used.

If the answer isn't in our documents, say "I don't have that in our documents. Ask [manager name]," and don't guess. Never give legal, medical or personal financial advice. Questions about pay, performance or a complaint about a coworker always go to [manager name].

3. Upload: your employee handbook, the SOPs your SOP Writer Agent produced, your policies, and a list of where the important templates live.

Use it: Tell the team: "Before you ask me, ask the Q&A agent." Keep a note of every question it can't answer.

Check it: Every question the agent can't answer is a missing document. Write it once (the SOP Writer Agent helps), upload it, and the interruptions keep shrinking.

Chapter 10: Your rollout plan

All 20 agents at a glance

#	Agent	Department	Runs	Hours saved / month	Savings / month
1	Inbox Triage	Operations	Weekdays	10	\$530
2	Meeting Notes	Operations	On demand	6	\$318
3	SOP Writer	Operations	On demand	6	\$372
4	Weekly Ops Report	Operations	Weekly	10	\$700
5	Prospect Research	Sales	On demand	5	\$265
6	Follow-Up	Sales	Weekdays	6	\$318
7	Proposal Builder	Sales	On demand	8	\$424
8	Content Repurposing	Marketing	Weekly	9	\$486
9	Newsletter	Marketing	Weekly	8	\$424
10	Competitor Watch	Marketing	Weekly	3.5	\$189
11	Review Reply	Marketing	Weekly	2.5	\$78
12	Support Reply	Customer service	Hourly or daily	8	\$248
13	Feedback Analyzer	Customer service	Monthly	3.5	\$189
14	Client Onboarding	Customer service	Per client	6	\$186
15	Collections	Finance	Weekly	3	\$96
16	Expense Categorizer	Finance	Monthly	3.5	\$123
17	Monthly Financial Summary	Finance	Monthly	3	\$171
18	Spend Auditor	Finance	Quarterly	0.5	\$78
19	Hiring Assistant	People	Per hire	3.3	\$173
20	Team Q&A	People	On demand	4	\$292
Total				about 109	\$5,660

At each role's BLS median pay plus benefits (see Chapter 3), 20 workdays or 4 weeks a month, review time subtracted, cash and revenue upside excluded. Agent 18's savings are mostly cancelled spend. Your numbers will differ; use the calculator.

Which three to start with

Pick by where your week actually goes:

- **Drowning in email and meetings?** Start with **Inbox Triage (1)**, **Meeting Notes (2)** and **Follow-Up (6)**. About \$1,170 a month.
- **Selling services or consulting?** Start with **Prospect Research (5)**, **Follow-Up (6)** and **Proposal Builder (7)**. About \$1,010 a month, plus the deals you stop losing.
- **Running a team?** Start with **Weekly Ops Report (4)**, **SOP Writer (3)** and **Team Q&A (20)**. About \$1,360 a month, and your team stops waiting on you.
- **Cash feels tight?** Start with **Collections (15)**, **Spend Auditor (18)** and **Monthly Financial Summary (17)**. The hours are smaller, but these are the agents that put money back in the bank.
- **Marketing never gets done?** Start with **Content Repurposing (8)**, **Newsletter (9)** and **Review Reply (11)**. About \$990 a month and a consistent presence.

Your 30-day rollout

Week 1: Basics and agent one. Set up your account (Chapter 1), time your three chosen tasks by hand, and build your first agent. Use it on demand every day.

Week 2: Schedule it and add agent two. Once agent one gets it right three times in a row, put it on a schedule. Build agent two.

Week 3: Agent three and the feedback loop. Build agent three. Every time you fix an agent's output the same way twice, add a rule to its instructions. That one habit is what turns a decent agent into a great one.

Week 4: Measure. Time your review of each agent's work and update the calculator. Decide whether to keep, adjust or retire each one, and pick the next three.

Earn autonomy in stages

Each agent moves up only when it has earned it:

1. **Draft only.** Everything it produces is a draft you approve. (Every agent starts here.)
2. **Light review.** After a month of drafts you rarely change, you skim instead of reading every line.
3. **Trusted for low-risk work.** For internal-only work (summaries, reports, categorizing), you stop reviewing every run and spot-check weekly.

Anything that reaches a customer, a bank account, an employee or the public stays at stage 1 or 2. That's not a limitation of the technology. It's good management.

The five most common mistakes

1. **Building ten agents in a weekend.** You'll maintain none of them. Build three, properly.
2. **Vague instructions.** "Help with email" fails. "Sort into three groups, flag these senders, draft replies under 80 words" works.
3. **No real files.** An agent without your FAQ, prices and examples writes generic answers. Feed it your actual material.
4. **Trusting a green checkmark.** A scheduled task that "completed" didn't necessarily do the job well. Read the output for the first few weeks.
5. **Never updating.** Prices change, policies change, people leave. Put a quarterly reminder on your calendar to reread each agent's instructions and files.

Your move

Choose your three agents from the list above. Block 90 minutes on your calendar this week to build the first one. Put the calculator next to you and time the task by hand first, so in 30 days you'll know exactly what it saved.

Bonus chapter: Find your next agent (and sell agents to clients)

Twenty agents is a strong start, but every business has its own time drains. This chapter gives you the method to find agent number 21 and beyond in your own business, and, if you build agents for clients, a simple way to find and sell the right first project.

The 20-minute workflow interview

The best agent ideas come from watching how the work actually gets done. Sit down with the person who does a job (or with yourself) and ask:

1. What part of your week feels like a time sink you'd love to hand off?
2. Walk me through it from start to finish. What starts it?
3. What are the steps, in order, and which tool or file do you use for each?
4. Where does the information come from, and where does the result go?
5. Which steps are copying, typing or reformatting the same kind of thing?
6. What judgment calls do you make, and how do you decide?
7. Where do you wait on someone else for input or approval?
8. What usually goes wrong, and how do you handle it?
9. How do you check the result before it goes out?
10. How often do you do it, and how long does each step take?
11. Any privacy, legal or compliance rules involved?
12. If you could only get rid of one or two steps, which would they be?

Then turn your notes into a ready-to-build agent:

Prompt: Turn an interview into an agent spec

Here are my notes from walking through a job: [paste notes or transcript]. Using this recipe (project, instructions, files, schedule, connected apps), write a spec for an AI agent that takes over as much of this job as is safe:

1. **Name and job:** one sentence.
2. **Process map:** every current step, labeled "agent does it," "agent drafts, person checks" or "stays human," with a one-line reason.
3. **Instructions:** the full standing instructions, ready to paste, including what it must never do.
4. **Files:** the documents and examples it needs.
5. **Schedule:** if it should run on its own, a self-contained task prompt (Job, Read, Steps, Deliver, Never).
6. **Savings:** minutes per run before and after, times [runs per month], times [hourly cost], as a monthly dollar figure.
7. **Open questions:** anything I need to find out before building it.

Where to look: common time drains by department

Use this table as a prompt for your interviews. Each row lists work that's frequent, follows a pattern and uses information that already exists somewhere, which makes it a good candidate for an agent.

Department	Common time drains	Agent ideas
Marketing	Content calendars, repurposing, reporting	Content repurposer, campaign report writer, audience research
Sales	Prospect research, follow-ups, proposals, CRM updates	Prospect researcher, proposal drafter, follow-up writer, call-notes summarizer
Admin	Scheduling, data entry, document prep	Meeting prep, form-to-spreadsheet, document assembler
Customer service	Repeat questions, ticket sorting, feedback	FAQ responder, ticket sorter, feedback-theme report
HR and recruiting	Screening, scheduling interviews, onboarding	Applicant screener, onboarding checklist, policy Q&A
Content and product	Course outlines, briefs, graphics prep	Brief writer, course outliner, product-description writer
Operations	SOPs, status reports, vendor follow-up	SOP writer, weekly status report, vendor chaser
Finance	Invoices, expense coding, collections	Invoice chaser, expense categorizer, cash summary
Legal and compliance	Contract review, policy updates	Contract first-pass reviewer (always checked by a professional)
IT and security	Access reviews, how-to questions	Access-review reminder, internal help desk
Research	Market and competitor tracking	Competitor watch, trend digest
Leadership	Weekly priorities, team pulse, board updates	Monday priorities brief, team-survey summary, board-update drafter

If you build agents for clients

VAs, freelancers and consultants are already being asked "Can you set up AI for us?" Here's how to turn that question into paid work without getting stuck in endless free advice.

Sell the first step, not the whole build. When a client asks for "an AI agent," they can't yet know which one, or what it should cost, and neither can you. Quote a big build too early and they'll stall while they gather estimates. Instead, sell a small, fixed-price first step: a workflow review of one department, where you interview the team, map the work and deliver a ranked list of agents with the savings for each. Then build the first one.

Start where wins are fast and visible. Marketing, sales, admin and content are the easiest places to show results quickly, and the team is less likely to feel replaced.

Lead with their numbers. Ask "What does this job cost you each month?" during the first conversation. Then use the savings calculator that comes with this book to show the cost of each job before and after. When a job costs a client \$1,200 a month and your setup fee is \$1,500, the decision makes itself.

Ask the four fit questions before you invest time in a proposal: Do we work well together? Are their expectations realistic? Is the problem specific and costly? Can they decide, is it urgent, and do they expect to invest?

Offer three ways to keep working together once the first agent is live: more agents as fixed-price projects, a monthly retainer to maintain and improve them, or training so their team can build their own.

The full call scripts (a 15-minute fit call, a 45-minute discovery call and 12 objections with responses) are in **The AI Client Kit**, included with the Playbook + Kit at virtualexpert.net/guide.

Your move

Run the workflow interview on one job this week, in your business or a client's. Put the notes through the agent-spec prompt and you'll have agent number 21, with its savings already worked out.

Want them built for you?

Everything in this book is designed for you to do yourself. But if you'd rather have an experienced operator look at where your hours go, pick the agents with the biggest payoff, and help you set them up, book a free discovery call with me at **virtualexpert.net/consulting**. We'll look at how your business runs today and where agents could save the most.

And if you set up agents for clients as a VA, freelancer or consultant, the **AI Client Playbook + Kit** (virtualexpert.net/guide) shows you how to find and win the clients to sell them to, with the call scripts to close them.

Plan names, prices and menu locations for Claude and ChatGPT were checked against Anthropic and OpenAI's own documentation in October 2026. These products change often; if a button has moved, the method still works.

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